Course Title: Islamic Studies/Ethics

Course Code: SS1007

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Why Do We Need Religion?

Why do we need religion? It is one of the most natural questions a thinking person can ask. Yet many of us grow up hearing what to believe without being encouraged to ask why. We learn prayers, customs and festivals from our families, but sometimes the meaning behind them remains unexplored. When questions are discouraged, faith can become cultural habit rather than conscious conviction.

So ask yourself honestly: Why do I believe in Allah? Could I explain my belief without simply repeating what I heard from my parents or teachers?

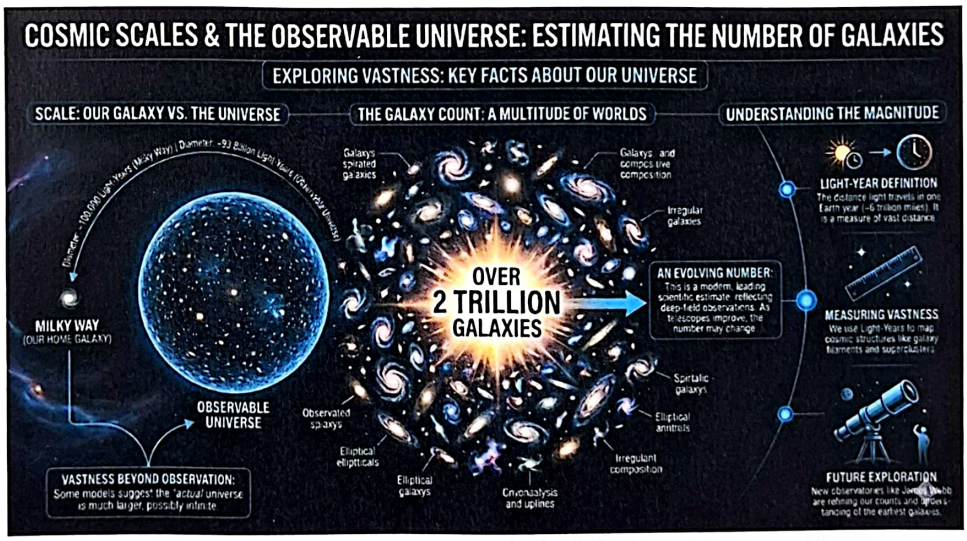
Do I understand the words I recite in salah? When I say "Subhana Rabbiyal A'la"

These questions do not weaken faith; they invite us to understand it.

Religion Answers the Question: Who?

Science is extraordinarily powerful at explaining how things happen: how stars' form, how cells divide, how the heart pumps and how a seed grows. Religion asks a different question: Who is behind existence, order and purpose? To feel the force of that question, look at seven familiar wonders and allow each one to question you.

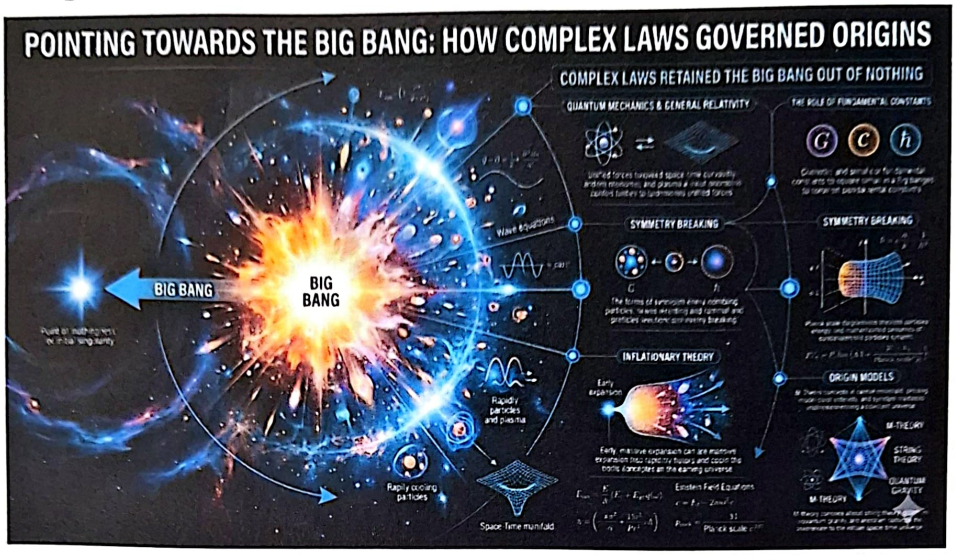
01 A Universe Beyond Imagination



The observable universe confronts us with a scale far beyond ordinary human experience.

How can a universe so vast exist at all? Why does it display patterns, structure and order rather than complete chaos? When you look at galaxies separated by unimaginable distances, is "it is simply there" a complete answer? Does the scale of the cosmos make the question of a Creator less important — or far more difficult to ignore?

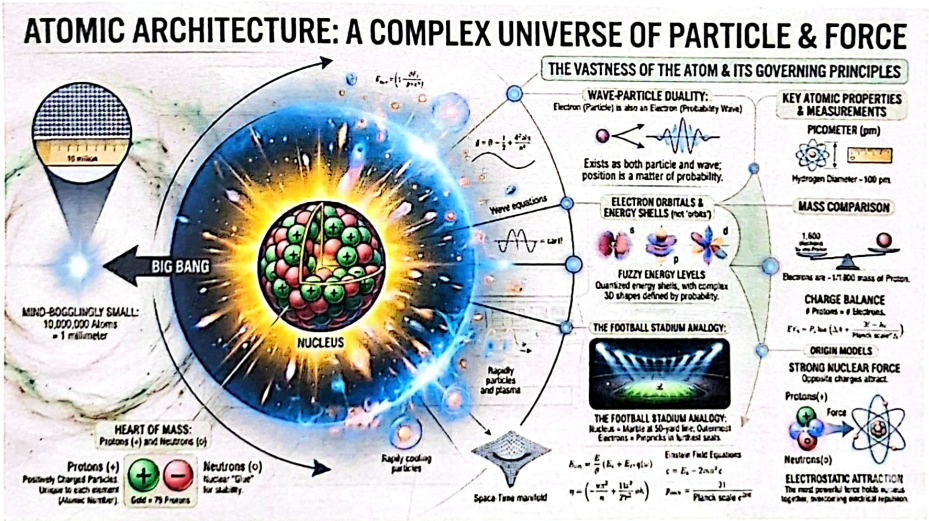
02 A Beginning: Why Is There Something Rather Than Nothing?



The origin of the universe raises questions that go beyond describing its expansion.

If the universe had an early beginning, where did its first reality come from? Why do matter and energy exist? Why are there laws such as gravity, electromagnetism and the nuclear forces for the universe to obey? Who established an intelligible order before human beings existed to study it? And behind every scientific description of the beginning, does the deeper question still remain: Why is there something rather than nothing?

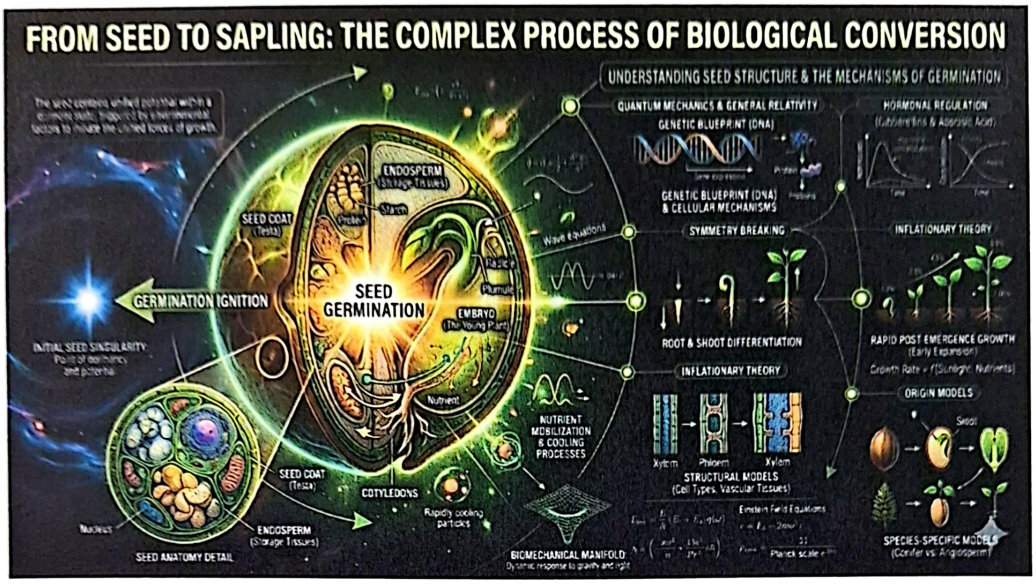
03 The Atom: Order in the Invisible World



Even the ordinary matter around us is built from an unseen and highly ordered world.

What is a desk, a stone, your hand or your brain made of at its smallest level? Why do atoms follow consistent laws instead of behaving randomly? How can invisible particles combine in reliable ways to produce water, air, cells and living bodies? We can study atomic structure and describe its behavior — but does describing the mechanism answer why such an ordered system exists in the first place?

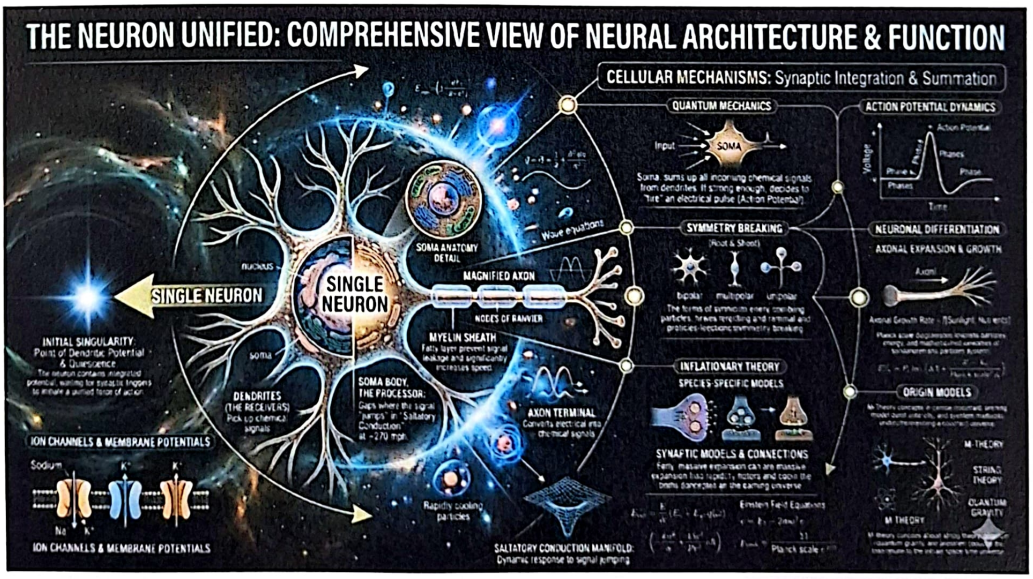
04 A Seed That Knows How to Become a Tree



A tiny seed contains the potential for roots, branches, leaves and future seeds.

How does something small enough to hold between two fingers become a living plant many times its original size? Who placed within it the information needed for roots to grow downward and shoots upward? Why does it respond to water, light, temperature and soil in an organized sequence? We can name germination, genes and hormones — but who gave nature a system in which a seed can unfold into a tree?

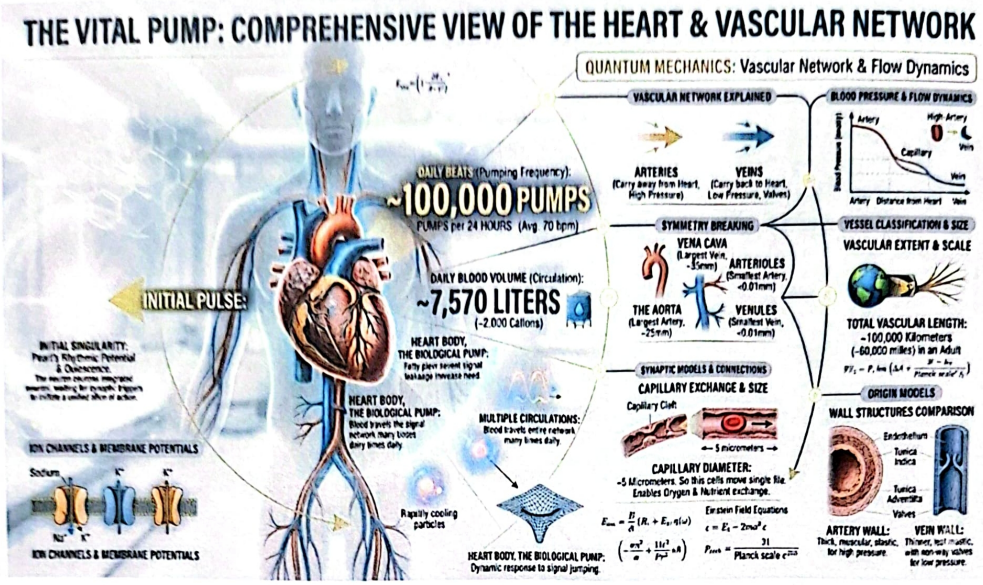
05 From a Tiny Beginning to a Thinking Human



Human development turns a minute beginning into a body capable of thought, memory and choice.

How does a tiny beginning develop into trillions of specialized cells? How does one group become heart tissue, another become bone, another become eyes, and another form the brain? Who directs this astonishing coordination while the developing child has no conscious control over it? And how does matter eventually become a human being who can think, love, remember and ask the very question: Who created me?

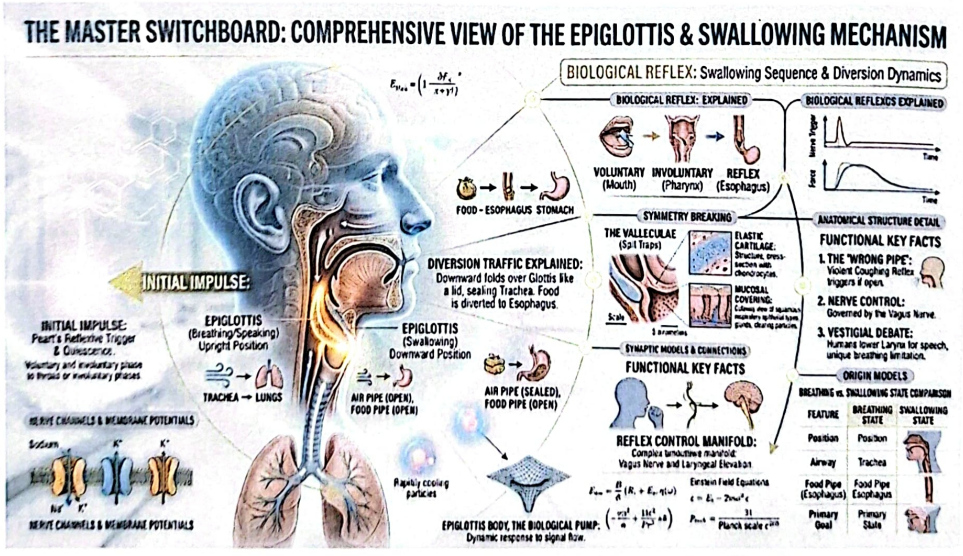
06 The Heart You Never Have to Command



The heart works continuously, long before we understand what it is doing.

Did you ever teach your heart how to beat? Do you remind it to pump while you sleep? Who designed a system in which chambers, valves, electrical signals and blood vessels work together every moment of life? Medicine can explain how the heartbeat is generated and how blood circulates — but when you become aware that this silent pump has served you since before birth, does explanation end wonder, or deepen it?

07 The Epiglottis: A Silent Guardian



A small flap of tissue helps protect the airway every time we swallow.

How often do you eat or drink without thinking about whether food will enter your lungs? How does a small structure coordinate with swallowing so quickly and repeatedly? Why is such a vital protective mechanism built into something most people never even notice? We can describe the reflex in anatomy and physiology, but does knowing how it works remove the question of why such purposeful coordination exists?

The Question the Qur'an Asks

After observing the universe and ourselves, the Qur'an directs the same question back to the human mind:

أَمْ خُلِقُوا مِنْ غَيْرِ شَيْءٍ أَمْ هُمُ الْخَالِقُونَ

"Were they created by nothing, or are they themselves the creators?" (Qur'an 52:35)

The verse does not ask us to stop thinking; it asks us to think more deeply. Did we create ourselves? Did existence create itself? Or does the existence of a dependent, ordered universe point beyond itself to a Creator?

Introduction to the Religion

What constitutes religion, and how is it defined across different contexts? How do individuals from diverse intellectual traditions, cultural regions, and religious backgrounds interpret its meaning and purpose? Furthermore, when, why, and how did religion originate? What motivates individuals to adhere to religious beliefs and practices? Why has religion remained a significant aspect of human society? This inquiry seeks to explore these and related questions through a structured and analytical approach.

Etymology:
Religion, derived from old French word **"Religiun"** means "Respect for what is sacred" and Latin word **"Religionem"** means **"Reverence for the gods".**

Modern Sense: "Recognition of, and obedience to a higher unseen power". Words "Creed", "Cult" and "Faith" are used as synonyms.

In Urdu, the word **"Mazhab مذہب"** which is originally an Arabic word means

"A way to go", "A path to walk", "A style", "A method" etc.

In Arabic, the word "Deen دین" is also used to describe a religion which literally means "Retaliation", "Recompense", "Requital", "Commandment", & "Judgment" etc., for example, Qur'an says"مَالِكِ يَوْمِ الدِّينِ " The Master of the Day of Judgment".

Word Religion in the holy Qur'an:
The most appropriate of the above-mentioned Arabic words in the sense of religion, is "Deen". Although, Qur'an uses some other words as well in this sense like " مِلَّةٌ ... Millah", "صِرَاطٌ ...Siraat", "مِنْهَاجٌ... Minhaaj", & " شِرْعَةٌ ... Shir'ah", but the word preferred and used most often in the divine guidance i.e. Qur'an and Hadith, it is "Deen دین" as it indicates to the requital and the recompense of the deeds in after life. The word "Mazhab مذہب" has not been used anywhere in divine scripture in the sense of religion as it does not express the exact sense of religion except in Urdu, instead, it is used in Arabic for "Point of view" & "School of thought".

Definitions & Concepts:

Religion has been interpreted in diverse ways by individuals across different regions, historical periods, and intellectual traditions. The following presents a selection of perspectives from Western scholars and philosophers, offering a broader and more nuanced understanding of the concept of religion.

Edward Burnett Tylor
1832-1917 (defines in his book "Primitive Culture") "The belief in spiritual being"

David Emile Durkheim
1858-1917 (writes in his book "The Elementary Forms of the Religious Life")

"Unified system of beliefs and practices relative to sacred things"

William James 1842-1910
(Describes in his book "The Varieties of Religious Experiences") "The feelings, acts and experiences of individual men in their solitude, whatever they may consider the divine."

The crux of the western ideas is that the Religion to them is "A relationship to sacred & spiritual things, feelings in solitude & experiences of individuals."

Divine Perspective: (Eastern Perspective)

"Religion is a complete code of life set and sent down by the Creator, the Lord (God) through His messengers from time to time to guide His slaves (Mankind & Jinn) to the success in life and afterlife".

Analysis:

An analysis of these various perspectives reveals several key observations. Notably, many Western scholars tend to conceptualize religion primarily as a matter of thought or belief, often minimizing its practical dimensions. This theoretical orientation is reflected in broader Western societal attitudes, where religion is frequently viewed as a private affair, and its involvement in public life—particularly in political and economic institutions—is often resisted. This individualistic interpretation of religion, grounded in the diversity of personal beliefs and spiritual orientations, has become increasingly pronounced in the modern Western context.

In contrast, from a theistic or divine perspective—particularly within the Islamic tradition—religion is inherently practical and comprehensive in scope. It functions not merely as a system of belief but as a complete way of life, with approximately 90% of its teachings centered on practice. Furthermore, religion in this context is understood as a collective and socially integrated phenomenon, rather than solely a personal matter. This collective dimension underscores the notion that individual and communal success in worldly life is deeply interconnected.

Need for Religion:

Religion is an essential need of mankind as it gives meanings to the essence of life, creates objective of existence and establishes the core of mankind. This conversation requires further elaboration on these aspects.

Demand of Nature:

This is mentionable that liberty and freedom have ever been fascinated and desired for human beings and the fact is that man, on account of his natural desire, prefers liberation and emancipation over all kinds of confinements and limitations which are the core of the religion, besides, on ground reality demonstrates that almost 80-85% of the world population is affiliated to some religion preferring restrictions and confinement set by the religion over emancipation and freedom which is astonishing for man himself. This enigma is uncomplicated to solve.

In fact, association with some religion is the demand of the innate human nature man has been created with.

Nature refers to an essential feature or characteristic of something by which that particular object is recognized and known. In case, if this feature is removed, that particular object remains not the same object any more. For instance, water is recognized and known

for its liquidity and flow, if this feature is removed, it might be called as ice but not water any more.

In the same way, man has been created with a proviso to be bound to believe in some unseen super natural power. No matter if man recognizes him or not, because it is experienced more than once and proved that one decides and determines for some task and struggles hard to achieve the goal, one eventually fails despite all his determinations. Besides, suffering from undesired diseases, mishaps, demises and disasters demonstrate even compel man to believe in some other contradictive powerful being existing as dominant and more influential than man himself. Man, on account of his nature, is frightened that this power may cause to harm or destruct him in case if gets angry with man. As an end result, man yields to that power to secure himself from any expected or unexpected failure and mischief and to collect maximum benefits and advantages. It is thus the religion takes birth and it is only the belief in God which can give security to the self and mind, peace to the soul, meaning to the individual and the satisfaction to the human nature.

The Innate Human Nature:

The word 'Innate' refers to build in essential human features. Man has been created with an innate nature that compels him to believe in an unseen super natural power as God. The connection between spirituality and genetics has long been a topic of both fascination and controversy. A famous scientist in his groundbreaking work, *The God Gene: How Faith Is Hardwired into Our Genes, Dean H. Hamer (2004)* introduced the hypothesis that certain aspects of human spirituality might be biologically encoded in our genes. This hypothesis suggests that spiritual experiences, including a person's capacity for transcendence, may have an evolutionary and genetic basis, with the gene VMAT2 (vesicular monoamine transporter 2) at the forefront of this hypothesis.

In *The God Gene*, Hamer proposes that VMAT2, a gene responsible for the transport of neurotransmitters in the brain, may play a critical role in an individual's predisposition toward mystical experiences and spiritual belief. Hamer's work posits that individuals with certain variations of the VMAT2 gene may be more likely to experience self-transcendence — a key trait in spirituality — thus linking biological factors to religious or mystical experiences (Hamer, 2004). This hypothesis is grounded in the neuroscientific understanding of how neurotransmitters such as serotonin, dopamine, and others influence mood, perception, and emotional states, potentially paving the way for transcendental experiences.

Dr. Andrew Newberg, a neuroscientist in the field of neuroethology, studies the connection between brain activity and spiritual experiences. His research suggests that specific brain regions are activated during mystical or religious states, indicating a neurobiological basis for spirituality. In *How God Changes Your Brain (2009)*, Newberg explains how practices like prayer and meditation can alter brain function, enhancing feelings of peace and connection. His findings support Dean H. Hamer's "God gene" hypothesis, suggesting that spirituality may be biologically influenced, as certain brain circuits are more activated in individuals predisposed to spiritual experiences.

Craves of Mind for the Knowledge of Essential Facts:

The human need for a creed primarily derives from men crave to know himself and the universe around him. The need to find answers has always occupied the concern of human philosophies without reaching the definite solutions. Since their creation, people have had the nagging questions "From where?", "To where?" and why?". They are

sometimes distracted by the demands of daily life, but they one-day return to these eternal questions.

Man wonders: from where did I and this immeasurable universe come?

Did I come into existence on my own or is there a creator who brought me to existence? Who is he? How am I related to him?

What about this vast land, sky, animal, vegetable, mineral, planets and stars? Why life is possible on Earth. When a man ponders over anything in the surrounding, he finds each and everything in our surrounding is a miracle but we don't perceive it like this because it happens on daily basis.

Did they come into existence on their own or is there some sovereign creator? What is after this life? What is after death? Where do we go after the short journey on this planet Earth? Does the story of life from birth to death have nothing beyond that? Do the virtuous who sacrifice their lives for good and truth meet the same end as the wicked and villainous who sacrifice others for their own desires and pleasure? Does life culminate only in death? Or is there some other life after death in which the virtuous are rewarded and the villainous are punished? And why was mankind brought into existence? Why were people endowed with mind, wisdom, knowledge and volition which distinguish them from all animals? Why does everything in heaven and on earth seem to be in his service? Is there a purpose to his existence? Does he have a mission in life? Or was he brought into existence only to eat as animals do and then expire as animals do? If there is a purpose to existence, what is it? How can this purpose be realized?

These questions have haunted man in every age and demanded answers that satisfy the intellect and soothe the heart. Answers like that are only found in religion or in a pure religious belief. It is religion that primarily teaches man that he came into existence neither by chance nor on his own but he was created by a great Creator Who is his God, That God made man, fashioned him perfectly, gave him due proportion, breathed soul into him, endowed him with hearing, eyesight, mind and heart and granted him all sorts of blessings starting as an embryo in a mother's womb.

Classification of Religions:

There are almost nine thousand religions including the tribal religions existing in the world. These religions have been classified into two major categories, Revealed & Non-revealed. Revealed refers to the claim by the followers in order to have some divine scripture for human guidance. Judaism, Christianity and Islam are considered as the revealed religions. Rest of the religions have been declared as non-revealed religions as they do not claim to have the divine scripture despite they have some sacred and holy books.

Theological Ideas:

The human search for meaning and transcendence has led to the development of a wide spectrum of theological and philosophical perspectives. These perspectives vary in their understanding of the divine, the cosmos, and the relationship between the two. The following outlines six major viewpoints regarding the existence and nature of God and the universe.

Atheism

Atheism is the doctrinal or philosophical position that denies the existence of God or any divine being. It often posits that the universe is self-existent and not contingent upon any supernatural entity for its origin or sustenance. Atheism ranges from explicit rejection of deities (strong atheism) to mere absence of belief in any god (weak atheism). Contemporary atheists often rely on naturalistic explanations of the universe and human existence, favoring empirical evidence over metaphysical speculation.[1]

Agnosticism

Agnosticism is characterized by a position of uncertainty or non-commitment regarding the existence or non-existence of God. Agnostics maintain that the question of divine existence is inherently unknowable or currently unknown, thus refraining from definitive belief or disbelief. The term was first coined by Thomas Huxley in the 19th century to describe his epistemological stance on metaphysical matters.[2]

Deism

Deism affirms the existence of a Creator who initiated the universe but denies divine revelation and the ongoing intervention of God in worldly affairs. Deists argue that reason and observation of the natural world are sufficient to discern the existence of a supreme being, without reliance on sacred texts or institutional religion. This view was prevalent among Enlightenment thinkers such as Voltaire and Thomas Jefferson.[3]

Pantheism

Pantheism is the belief that God and the universe are identical, asserting that the divine is immanent in all aspects of the natural world. Rather than viewing God as a personal, transcendent being, pantheists equate divinity with the laws of nature and the cosmos itself. This worldview is found in various philosophical and religious traditions, including certain strands of Hinduism and the writings of Baruch Spinoza.[4]

Monotheism

Monotheism is the belief in the existence of a single, all-powerful, and transcendent God. This worldview forms the theological foundation of the Abrahamic religions—Judaism, Christianity, and Islam—all of which emphasize a personal deity who is both the creator and sustainer of the universe. Monotheism posits that divine revelation is accessible through sacred scriptures and prophetic traditions.[5]

Polytheism

Polytheism denotes belief in multiple deities, each typically associated with specific aspects of nature, human life, or cosmic functions. This system was dominant in ancient civilizations such as Greece, Rome, and Egypt, where gods and goddesses governed various realms like war, love, the sea, and the harvest. Polytheistic traditions often allow for fluid worship and integration of local deities.[6]

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[1] Martin, M. (2007). *The Cambridge Companion to Atheism*. Cambridge University Press.

[2] Thrower, J. (1980). *The Alternative Tradition: A Study of Unbelief in the Ancient World*. Mouton Publishers.

[3] Israel, J. (2001). *Radical Enlightenment: Philosophy and the Making of Modernity 1650–1750*. Oxford University Press.

[4] Nadler, S. (2006). *Spinoza's Ethics: An Introduction*. Cambridge University Press.

[5] Armstrong, K. (1993). *A History of God: The 4,000-Year Quest of Judaism, Christianity and Islam*. Ballantine Books.

[6] Burkert, W. (1985). *Greek Religion: Archaic and Classical*. Harvard University Press.

Introduction to the Islam

Islam (اسلام) is the name of a famous religion amongst the religions of the world. It is the religion of truth containing both thoughts and practices. According to the divine scripture 'Qur'an', it is the true religion with Allah the Exalted and the final and complete version of the Divine guidance.

Etymology

The word "Islam (اسلام)" is an Arabic word derived from "Salama (سلم)" which literally means "Peace" and "Safeness". The word "Islam (اسلام)" literally means "Obedience", "Submission" and "Surrender".

Definition & Concept

A complete code of life revealed by Allah (The Creator, the Owner, the Sustainer & the Lord) to His Prophets & Messengers (From Adam AS to the last of His messengers Muhammad a) from time to time to guide His slaves (Mankind & Jinn) for their success in life and afterlife.

Important Note 1:

Islam is unlike other religions as they contain some typical traditions and customs particularly at three occasions i.e. the birth of a child, the marriage and the death of a person, or maximum some rituals are being performed as worships. They do not have systematic and organized structure of worships, family dealings, social dealings, economic system, political and legal affairs based upon their religion.

On the other hand, Islam is a complete code of life and is fully equipped with teachings for every aspect of life. For instance, along with above mentioned disciplines of life, Islam also stresses upon daily routine of life such as eating, drinking, sleeping, dressing, and also commands to perform the necessities of daily life, as per the commandments of Islam.

Secondly, Islam is a divine religion set, chosen and revealed by Allah (The Creator, The Owner and The Lord of all the worlds). It is not a man-made religion. Its teachings are genuinely from The Lord and are beyond doubts. Allah the Almighty has sent its last version of Divine guidance to the last of His Messengers, Prophet Muhammad (a) through one of His angels Jibraeel e who is considered as the chief of all of the angels as described by Almighty the Allah. He reveals in the Qur'an;

وَإِنَّهُ لَتَنزِيلُ رَبِّ الْعَالَمِينَ ۝ نَزَلَ بِهِ الرُّوحُ الْأَمِينُ ۝ عَلَىٰ قَلْبِكَ لِتَكُونَ مِنَ الْمُنذِرِينَ ۝ بِلِسَانٍ عَرَبِيٍّ مُّبِينٍ ۝

And truly, this is the revelation from the lord of all worlds. The trustworthy spirit (Jibraeel) brought it down. Upon your heart, so that you may become one of the warner. In plain Arabic language.[7]

The Subject of Islam:

The Subject refers towards the study of some particular thing or object which, as a topic, is discussed under a discipline. For example, human body is discussed under medical

7 The Qur'an-26:192-195

science. Therefore, it is the subject of medical science. And machine is the subject of engineering because it is discussed under the discipline of engineering.

In the same way, when Islam is considered as a discipline and the code for life, definitely there should be some subject to be discussed in it too. And the subject for the entire Islamic teachings is the human beings and Jinns being slaves to Allah the Exalted, as He says:

وَمَا خَلَقْتُ الْجِنَّ وَالْإِنْسَ إِلَّا لِيَعْبُدُونِ

"I did not create mankind and Jinn except for the Purpose that they should worship me."[8]

Islam reveals the teachings through which human beings may enable themselves to become good slaves to Allah the Almighty.

The Objective of Islam:

The objective behind this revelation of Islam is: To provide complete guidance to mankind and Jinn that leads them to the success in life and afterlife.

A noteworthy point should also be remembered that the actual concept of success, as per the interpretation of divine scripture al-Qur'an, lies down with safe removal from the fire of hell and the entrance into paradise. Allah the Almighty says:

فَمَن زُحْزِحَ عَنِ النَّارِ وَأُدْخِلَ الْجَنَّةَ فَقَدْ فَازَ وَمَا الْحَيَاةُ الدُّنْيَا إِلَّا مَتَاعُ الْغُرُورِ

"So, whoever is safely removed from the fire of Hell and admitted to Paradise, he succeeded indeed. And the worldly life is not but the goods of delusion".[9]

The verse reveals that beyond this actual success, no worldly success is appreciable and reliable especially when this world itself is a mortal and until the man is safely removed from the fire of Hell.

Fore face of Islam:

In a very famous Hadith of Prophet Muhammad ﷺ, entitled with Hadith-e-Jibraeel, Prophet Muhammad ﷺ introduced Islam by its face features as a reply to a question asked by Jibreel ؑ. For details, Hazrat Umar ؓ, reports that once Jibraeel ؑ came to see Prophet Muhammad ﷺ in the attire of a man while some of the companions (including reporter) were sitting around him in the holy mosque of Madinah. He asked few questions which were replied by the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ.

1: Islam

Jibraeel eked the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ about Islam, to which he replied that it consists of five pillars:

Shahada: Declaration of faith in the oneness of God and the prophet hood of Prophet Muhammad ﷺ.

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[8] The Qur'an-51:56
[9] The Qur'an-3:185

Salah: Performing the five daily prayers.

Zakat: Giving alms to the poor and needy.

Sawm: Fasting during the month of Ramadan.

Hajj: Pilgrimage to Mecca for those who are able.

2: Iman (Faith):

Jibraeel e then asked about Iman (faith), and the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ explained that it involves belief in:

Allah

His angels

His books

His messengers

The Day of Judgment

Predestination (that good and bad are decreed by Allah).

3: Ihsan (Excellence in Worship):

Jibraeel e asked about Ihsan, and the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ explained that it is to worship Allah as if you see Him, and even though you do not see Him, you should know that He sees you.[10]

It is important to note that the teachings mentioned above represent only a small portion of Islamic teachings, not the entirety of Islam. Just as a person has organs and body parts beyond just the features of the face, Islam encompasses much more than what has been outlined here.

The Structure of Islam

Islam

├─I. Foundations

│ ├─1. Tawheed (Oneness of God)

│ ├─2. Risalah (Prophethood)

│ └─3. Akhirah (Hereafter)

├─II. Religious Structure

│ ├─A. Beliefs (Iman – 6 Articles)

├─Believe in oneness of God

├─Believe in the Prophets

[10] Sahih Muslim:93

- Believe in Angels
- Believe in holy Books
- Believe in the Day of Judgment
- Believe in the Desitny

- **B. Practices (Ibadah – 5 Pillars)**
  - Shahadah
  - Salah/Prayer
  - Sawm/Fasting
  - Zakah/Obligatory Charity
  - Hajj/Pilgrimage
- **C. Sources of Law/Jurisprudence**
  - Qur'an
  - Sunnah
  - Ijma (Consensus)
  - Qiyas (Analogy)

III. Islamic Systems

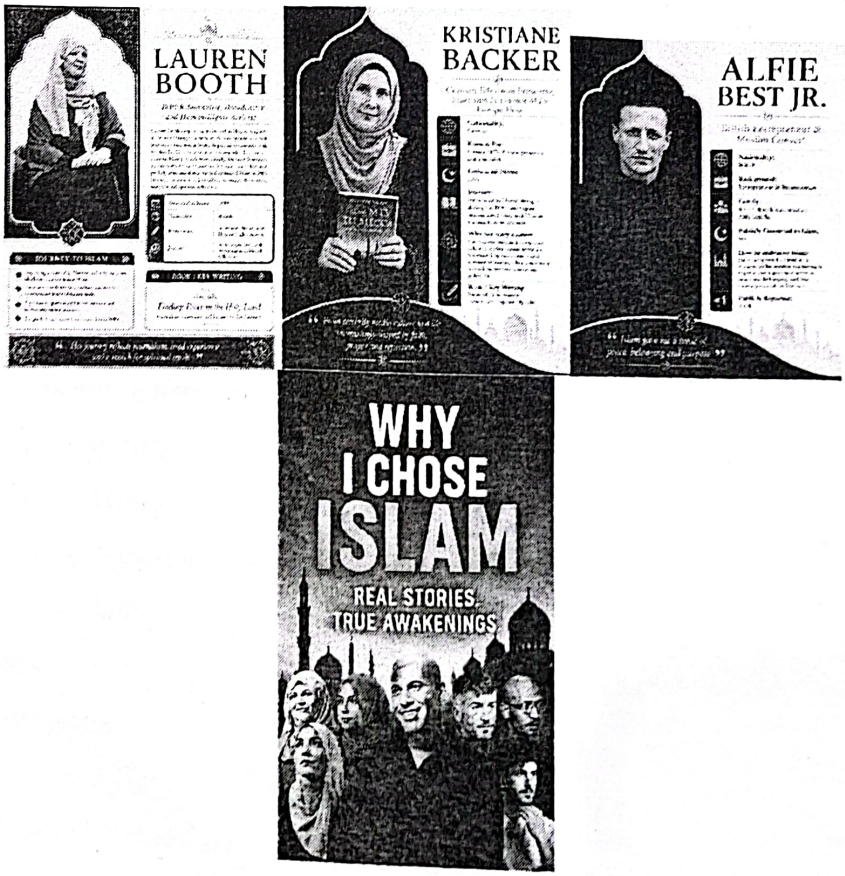
- **A. Social System**
  - Esteem system of Soul/Human Dignity
  - Family structure
  - Marriage & divorce laws
  - Gender roles
  - Rights of neighbors, orphans, etc.
- **B. Ethical System**
  - Halal vs Haram
  - Personal integrity
  - Justice ('Adl)
  - Social values
  - Antiquates
  - Accountability before God
- **C. Political System**

| | ├─Shura (Consultation)
| | ├─Caliphate / Imamate concepts
| | ├─Governance under Sharia
| | └─Justice & law enforcement
| └─D. Economic System
| ├─Zakat (Wealth purification)
| ├─Prohibition of Riba (Interest)
| ├─Islamic banking & finance
| └─Principles of fair trade & charity

Why Islam?

The authenticity of Islam is often highlighted by the experiences of converts in the whole world, who find its teachings deeply compelling and transformative. Many converts are drawn to Islam's clear monotheism, the emphasis on personal responsibility, and the sense of belonging to a global community. The Qur'an's timeless and unaltered preservation, coupled with the simplicity and coherence of its message, offers a sense of authenticity that resonates with individuals seeking spiritual fulfillment and clarity in a complex world. Converts often speak of the inner peace they find in Islam's structured way of life, its emphasis on justice, and its comprehensive moral guidance, all of which stand in contrast to the perceived emptiness or disillusionment in other aspects of contemporary life. The growing number of conversions in these regions reflects Islam's enduring authenticity and relevance, as individuals from diverse backgrounds embrace its message of faith, unity, and purpose.

As a **case study**, carefully explore the conversion journeys of the Muslims **mentioned below.** Reflect on the questions they asked, the experiences that shaped their thinking, and the reasons that ultimately led them to embrace Islam. Studying these journeys can deepen your understanding of faith, encourage thoughtful reflection, and strengthen your own conviction. You are also encouraged to visit the **Towards Eternity** YouTube channel, which features a wide range of personal conversion stories, interviews, and discussions from people of diverse backgrounds.



Finality of Islam

Islam (The final version, revealed upon Prophet Muhammad a) is the only religion with Allah the Almighty in true sense.

إِنَّ ٱلدِّينَ عِندَ ٱللَّهِ ٱلْإِسْلَٰمُ

"Truly, the religion with Allah is Islam".[11]

Also one should not die without believing and following Islam. As Allah has warned clearly in the Qur'an stating;

يَٰٓأَيُّهَا ٱلَّذِينَ ءَامَنُواْ ٱتَّقُواْ ٱللَّهَ حَقَّ تُقَاتِهِۦ وَلَا تَمُوتُنَّ إِلَّا وَأَنتُم مُّسْلِمُونَ

"O you, who believe, be afraid of Allah, as He deserves to be feared, and let not yourself die save as Muslims."[12]

The concept of success in true sense i.e. the success in afterlife totally depends upon following this final version of Islam, and there is no other possible way or key to success. No other religion is acceptable to Allah, the Lord and the Master of the Day of Judgment. Allah has announced it in the Qur'an saying,

وَمَن يَبْتَغِ غَيْرَ ٱلْإِسْلَٰمِ دِينًا فَلَن يُقْبَلَ مِنْهُ وَهُوَ فِى ٱلْءَاخِرَةِ مِنَ ٱلْخَٰسِرِينَ

"And whoever seeks a religion other than Islam, It will never be accepted from him, and he, in the hereafter, will be among the losers".[13]

Also, dying without having faith in this final version of Islam will cause the definite & eternal punishment in Hell. Allah the Almighty states;

إِنَّ ٱلَّذِينَ كَفَرُواْ وَمَاتُواْ وَهُمْ كُفَّارٌ فَلَن يُقْبَلَ مِنْ أَحَدِهِم مِّلْءُ ٱلْأَرْضِ ذَهَبًا وَلَوِ ٱفْتَدَىٰ بِهِۦٓ أُوْلَٰٓئِكَ لَهُمْ عَذَابٌ أَلِيمٌ وَمَا لَهُم مِّن نَّٰصِرِينَ

"Those who disbelieve and die as disbelievers, an earth-full of gold even shall never be accepted from any of them, even if one were to offer it as ransom. They are the ones for whom there is a painful punishment, and for them there are no helpers." [14]

It has been categorically communicated in a hadith in following words: Abu Huraira ﷺ narrated that the Messenger of Allah ﷺ said;

"I swear by the one who holds the life of Muhammad, any of the Jew or Christian from among the people who comes to know about me, and then dies without having faith in what I have been sent with (Islam), he will definitely be among the hell members". [15]

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[11] The Qur'an-3:19
[12] The Qur'an-3:102
[13] The Qur'an-3:85
[14] The Qur'an-3:91
[15] Sahih Muslim:386

The Belief System of Islam

Definition of Belief (Iman) in Islam

The Arabic word for belief is "Iman", derived from the root ' a-m-n (أ-م-ن), which conveys the sense of security, affirmation, and trust. Linguistically, Iman means to affirm something as true and to feel secure in it.

Technical Definition (Islamic Terminology):

In Islamic theology, Iman refers to the firm conviction and acceptance of the truth of what was revealed by Allah through His Prophet Muhammad ﷺ. It is a comprehensive concept that encompasses belief in the heart, affirmation by the tongue, and actions by the limbs.

"Iman is to believe with the heart, confess with the tongue, and act with the limbs."

Belief in Islam is not limited to intellectual assent but is manifested through practice, character, and commitment.

The Importance of Belief in Islam

Belief is the foundation of a Muslim's identity and the first requirement for entering Islam. Without belief, acts of worship or righteous deeds are not accepted by Allah. The Qur'an emphasizes belief as the first pillar of righteousness and the gateway to salvation.

"Indeed, those who have believed and done righteous deeds — they will have the Gardens of Paradise as a lodging."[16]

The Fundamental Beliefs in Islam (Articles of Faith)

The essential beliefs of Islam are known as the Six Articles of Faith (Arkan al-Iman). These are derived from the Qur'an and authentic hadith, especially the famous Hadith of Jibrīl (Gabriel)

Interrelation between Belief and Practice

In Islam, belief is not merely theoretical. It must be accompanied by righteous action. The Qur'an often couples "belief and good deeds" emphasizing the dynamic relationship between faith and practice.

Articles of Faith in Islam

1) Iman bi-Tawhid: Belief in the Oneness of Allah

2) Iman bil-Mala' ikah: Belief in Angels

3) Iman bil-Kutub: Belief in the Books

4) Iman bir-Rusul: Belief in the Prophets

5) Iman bil-Yawm al-Akhira: Belief in the Last Day

6) Iman bil-Qadar:Belief in Divine Decree

[16] The Qur'an, 18-107

Recommended Readings for Further Study:

- The Fundamentals of Tawheed, by Dr. Bilal Philips
- Islamic Belief System, by Jamal al-Din Zarabozo
- Selected chapters from Sahih Muslim and Sahih Bukhari on Iman

Iman bil-Tawhid (Belief in the Oneness of God)

Tawhid means attributing Oneness to Allah the Almighty and describing Him as being One and Unique, with no partner or peer in His Essence and Attributes.

Tawhid is the most sensitive and significant creed in the sight of Allah the Almighty. The foundation of Islam is based on this creed. Until and unless we don't have deep cognition of this creed our faith is at stake. We can never achieve the essence of Iman without comprehension of this belief. Without recognizing Him, we will never be able to develop a relationship with him.

We should strive to learn this fundamental concept of Monotheism. We should have our reasons and logic based on the Qur'an and Hadith to strengthen our belief in the existence of Allah the Almighty. We should develop a personal connection with Allah the exalted. When we will recognize Him in the true sense only then we will be able to follow Him in true letter and spirit. As mentioned in the Qur'an:

إِنَّمَا يَخْشَى اللَّهَ مِنْ عِبَادِهِ الْعُلَمَاءُ

Those who truly fear Allah, among His servants, who know Allah.[17]

Tawhid is the primary and core subject of the Qur'an. There is a hadith that mentions that Surah Ikhlas is one-third of the Qur'an.[18] Surah Ikhlas has been given this status because of the theme mentioned in it. It solely elucidates the concept of Tawhid.

قُلْ هُوَ اللَّهُ أَحَدٌ ۝ اللَّهُ الصَّمَدُ ۝ لَمْ يَلِدْ وَلَمْ يُولَدْ ۝ وَلَمْ يَكُنْ لَهُ كُفُوًا أَحَدٌ ۝

(O Esteemed Messenger!) Proclaim: 'He is Allah, Who is the One. Allah is the Transcendent of all, the Protector and Far-Superior to all.He has not begotten any, nor is He begotten. Nor is there anyone equal to Him.'[19]

Allah the Almighty is the most Unique and Exalted as He is the creator. Nothing can be brought into His comparison. He is the most Supreme Being in the entire world. He alone is the Sustainer of all the Universes and the whole creation. Everything is dependent on Him but He is independent of everyone. His being is the practical manifestation of absolute Oneness.

Importance of Tawhid in the Qur'an

Tawhid is the main theme, crux and focal teaching of the Qur'an.

And We did not send any Messenger before you, but We revealed to him (saying): none has the right to be worshipped but I (Allah), so worship Me (Alone).[20]

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[17] The Qur'an:5-8
[18] Sahih al-Bukhari:5013
[19] The Qur'an: 112:1-4
[20] The Qur'an: 21-5

And at another place in the Qur'an, Allah the Almighty mentioned,

And verily, We have sent among every Ummah (nation) a Messenger (proclaiming): Worship Allah (Alone), and avoid (or keep away from) Taghut.[21]

Repeatedly stating the subject of Tawhid in diverse ways and styles and at different places in the Qur'an indicates the emphasis and significance of the belief of Tawhid. Allah the Almighty used the exact statement for other Prophets in the Qur'an regarding Tawhid.

So, till the last messenger, the message of the Oneness of Allah the Almighty was sent to mankind which shows its high importance.

Types of Tawhid

- Rububiyah (Lordship)
- Uluhiyyah (Worship)
- Asmaa Was-Sifaat (Names and Attributes)

Rububiyah (Lordship)

This category is based on the fundamental concept that Allah the Almighty alone caused all things to exist when there was nothing. This is known as creation Ex Nihilo (Latin for creation out of nothing) is the doctrine that matter is not eternal but had to be created by some divine creative act.

He sustains and maintains creation without any need from it or for it and He is the sole Lord of the universe and its inhabitants without any real challenge to His sovereignty.

In Arabic, the word used to describe this creator sustainer quality is Rububiyah which is derived from the root "Rabb" (Lord). This is proved by Allah the Almighty statement in Surah Al-Fatihah, verse one where He says, "[All] praise is due] to Allah, Lord of the world's mankind, jinn, and all that exists]".

According to this category, since God is the only real power in existence, it is He who gave all things the power to move and to change. Everything is dependent on His become and He is the only independent Being. All these facts have been explained in Sura al-Naml in a comprehensive way from 60-65 verse.

Uluhiyyah (Worship)

This means having a firm conviction that only Allah is the true and only God worthy of worship. In Arabic, the term ibadah (worship) is associated with obedience, subservience, and submission. It has been defined by some scholars as "complete love accompanied by complete submission". Thus, worship in all its forms cannot be dedicated to anyone else besides Allah the Almighty. It is important to point out that the concept of worship is all-embracing. Worship transcends the five pillars of Islam and covers all the good things and deeds that please Allah the Almighty. Therefore, things like supplication, reliance, obedience, subservience, and submission would be covered by this definition. All these things should be done solely for the sake of Allah the Almighty.

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[21] The Qur'an: 16-6

Evidence of this type of Tawhid is in Allah the Almighty statement "And I Allah did not create the jinn and men except that they should worship Me (alone)". Surah Zariyat: 56]

'Kalima' as an example of Uluhiyyah

• ilah- one who is worshipped, on account of greatness and power is considered worthy to be worshipped.

• La ilaha illallah –There is no ilah other than one great being known by the name Allah the Almighty.

• It means that in the whole of the universe, there is absolutely no being worthy to be worshipped other than Allah the Almighty.

• That is only to Him our heads should bow in submission and adoration.

Our Prayers, charity, dua, tawaf, sajda, etc. are the acts of worship. If we perform them for anyone else other than Allah the Almighty, then it is Shirk.

Asmaa Was-Sifaat (Names and Attributes)

This category of Tawhid has five main aspects:

• Unity of Allah the Almighty names and attributes to be maintained in the first aspect.

• Allah the Almighty must be referred to according to how He and His Prophet Muhammad ﷺ have described Him instead of explaining His names and attributes by giving them meanings other than their obvious meanings.

• The second aspect involves referring to Allah the Almighty as He has referred to Himself without giving Him any new names or attributes.

• In the third aspect of Tawhid al-Asmaa wasSifaat (اسماءوصفات) Allah the Almighty is referred to without giving Him the attributes of His creation. For example, it is claimed in the Bible and Torah that Allah the Almighty spent the first six days creating the universe and then slept on the seventh. For this reason, Jews and Christians take either Saturday or Sunday as a day of rest in which work is looked at as a sin.

• The fourth aspect of this category requires that any human should not be given the attributes of Allah the Almighty to His Almighty level. In reality, all the attributes belong to Allah the Almighty in true essence. He has distributed His attributes to the creation for a certain period e.g. a man can be Raheem but not to the level of Allah the Almighty. All the attributes of Allah are incomparable as they are not dependent on anyone but the attributes of the Creator are independent. The attributes of creation have a start and end time but His attributes are free from creation and eternal like Creator. The abilities of creation are limited and confined like them and all the abilities of the Creator are limitless and perpetual.

The Example of Hayy and Qayyum

Al-Hayy (the Ever-Living) and al-Qayyum (the Self-Subsisting) are two of His exclusive and incomparable attributes. They affirm that He alone possesses true and